playing with. But right from the beginning of my career, I had something that was rare for a newbie like me: the pull.

Whenever I'd descend the elevator of any hotel in any city or country where we were on tour, the autograph hunters – folks these days just take selfies; the autograph, sadly, is a lost art form – who usually gathered around the senior, more well-known players, would simply abandon them and make a dash for me. It was after such moments that I began noticing that I'd inadvertently made some of my teammates insecure. My ears started picking up chatter too. I was 'the kid' who was 'just starting'. How could I get all 'the lift', it was asked. I heard it all, the chides and the uncomfortable silences, but I kept my head down and didn't make a big deal of it.

Greatness isn't an easy prospect. There are stars and then there are legends. I'm not talking about those who've been knighted. I'm talking about the gods of the game. It's a tough transition – there are plenty of stars in the Pakistan teams of yesteryears, but only a handful of legends.

Professional jealousy is understandable. If it forces you to up your game and motivates you to perform better on the field, it's healthy even. I encourage competitive behaviour. But when you mix jealousy with camaraderie and let it get in the way of teamwork, then it's all over. When you let your bad *niyat*, your ill intentions, get in the way of your job, which is to perform for your country, fans, family, honour – all for the love of cricket – then God makes things even tougher for you, and you spiral downwards.

There are haters everywhere. There's an entire movement online of trolls and hatemongers who exist on social media – or anti-social media, rather – who are anti-Afridi. I've heard that some of them actually get paid by some lobbies within the cricketing ecosystem to do what they do against me. Misbah-ul-Haq, one of our finest and most successful former Test captains, faces the same problem. Perhaps it's because we are both stars that we face these issues. I must confess that I do find the musings online rather interesting. But I don't worry about them too much.

Still, trolling is ugly. Super ugly. Organized trolling is a dark world by itself. But jealousy is a different beast altogether – it can undo the finest of men, even former world champions. If I don't get along with someone, I don't get along. Things are probably not meant to be pleasant at all times with that person. It was the same with Aamer Sohail when he hurt me with his comments. End of story.

Here's the truth. I will not always be *the* Shahid Afridi. I will not always be in a glitzy uniform or live a glamourous life. I will not always be 'one of the most dangerous players' of the game, strong of body and bank. Someone better, faster and stronger will come along. And then I will have to hang up my boots. I will err. I will fade away. These are my standards, weaknesses and strengths. These are the truths I must live with. These are the realities I am humbled by.